

A Qualitative Analysis of Community Food, Community Systems, and Community Care

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Introduction

Food insecurity is a public health problem that should be addressed urgently. The American College of Physicians posits that “food insecurity functions as a social driver of health, directly negatively impacting health status and outcomes, which can further negatively impact employment and income and increase medical expenditures—all of which exacerbates food insecurity.”ⁱ Other public health research efforts demonstrate that food insecurity is associated with chronic disease.ⁱⁱ Food insecurity and poor health are both independent products of structural racism that also interact to exacerbate negative health outcomes for Black and Brown peoples in the United States.

Feeding America compiles data from The U.S. Census Bureau and Bureau of Labor Statistics to estimate food insecurity in the United States. 11 counties make up the Metro Atlanta area: Cherokee, Clayton, Cobb, DeKalb, Douglas, Fayette, Forsyth, Fulton, Gwinnett, Henry, and Rockdale County. The average food insecurity estimate across these counties for 2022 was 10.4%. For the state, that number was 13.1%.ⁱⁱⁱ With contemporary changes in food prices, these numbers may worsen as the commercial price of food increases. Researchers propose that food systems work can address the growing food insecurity problem.

The United States Department of Agriculture (USDA) defines food systems as “place-specific clusters of agricultural producers of all kinds—farmers, ranchers, fishers—along with consumers and institutions engaged in producing, processing, distributing, and selling foods.”^{iv} The Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations defines a sustainable food system as one that “delivers food security and nutrition for all in such a way that the economic, social and environmental bases to generate food security and nutrition for future generations are not compromised.”^v This research is concerned with the latter definition and especially how community-focused and justice-driven efforts fit into this paradigm and further advance it.

This qualitative research project will engage the many food producers, growers, land stewards, cultural workers, and agricultural organizations who create a unique mosaic of food resources in the Metro Atlanta area. Referred to as “community agricultural stakeholders” throughout this study, this collective of people and organizations augment, subvert, and leverage their commercial and communal food systems to promote food security within their communities. More specifically, “community agricultural stakeholder” is an umbrella phrase that includes food producers like farmers, farm managers, gardeners, and homesteaders. It also includes organizational and institutional personnel like farmers market staff, food-focused nonprofit organizational staff, food access community organizers, food studies academics, and other concerted efforts to organize people around food production. Commercial food systems include the production, processing, distribution, marketing, and consumption of food on a large scale, by commercial retailers, and with the primary goal of profit. Communal food systems include the production, processing, distribution, marketing, and consumption of food on a local

and/or communal scale, by non-commercial retailers, with the primary goal of providing a social service or addressing a social need.

Research suggests a middle ground between communal and commercial food production. A space where the former can benefit from infrastructural and procedural support, and the latter can benefit from a shift in power dynamics that enfranchises local producers, is more responsive to community needs, and is better integrated into the environmental needs of each locale. Further research is warranted to understand how they coexist, conflict, challenge, and change each other. Further research would also extend the body of work conceptualizing future food systems that promote food security. Therefore, this mini study explores how community agricultural stakeholders in the Metro Atlanta area create a communal food system that operates parallel to their commercial food system. It seeks to understand their perceived role in Metro Atlanta food systems and addressing food insecurity.

Literature Review

This literature review evaluated what research exists concerning the public health problem of food insecurity and the components or dynamics of urban food systems that may contribute to this problem.^{vi} Two questions guided this review: 1) What social, economic, and spatial factors of a community create the conditions for food insecurity? 2) What are the different components of a food system and how do they impact food security? Review strategies included a systematic search of the literature using Google Scholar, JSTOR, and Emory University's Robert W. Woodruff Libraries Article Search. Keyword searches included the following words and phrases: "Urban food systems," "Atlanta urban food systems," "Atlanta food insecurity," "Atlanta food systems," and "Food systems AND Atlanta." The initial evaluation of articles consisted of a review of the title, abstract, discussion, and conclusions sections. An in-depth evaluation of articles that passed the initial evaluation immediately followed the initial screening. The inclusion criteria were peer-reviewed research published online and in full. The exclusion criteria were articles published before 2014, and articles written in languages other than English. Three themes emerged from the literature review: justice and sovereignty, food insecurity, and policy and governance.

Theme 1 – Justice and Sovereignty are social factors that impact food security

Food justice and sovereignty are dominant topics in discourses around food access in the United States. The former represents many contexts where food insecurity was deemed a collective issue worth collective action. The latter originates in the Global South within peasant movements but has become increasingly popular in domestic efforts towards food justice. Clendenning argues that while food justice movements share some of the same grassroots goals and methods of organizing, they ultimately lack the political and ideological rigor needed to

create transformational change. Because food justice movements operate under the neoliberal frameworks of supply, demand, and consumption, movements—like the historical movements in Oakland and New Orleans—have limited impact.^{vii} What food systems research has yet to uncover is how people leverage these systems to promote food security within their communities. Other researchers argue that productive food systems require neoliberal considerations around technology and information. Even they concede that social and political considerations must also inform food systems. In his conceptualization of a “smart food city,” Damian Maye describes a city-level food system with multi-use and sustainable agricultural innovations that value cultural norms and practices around food and make them efficient via technological and informational advancements.^{viii} While Maye looks towards the future, Dr. Monica White uses the past and present to demonstrate how African Americans worked toward social liberation via their food systems in her analysis of cooperative urban agricultural movements. Dr. White delineates how agricultural resistance bolstered the collective freedom struggle for Black Americans as they worked collaboratively to fight for voting rights, access to land, food security, and social justice in the Jim Crow South.^{ix}

Theme 2 – Policy and Governance are food system components that impact food security.

The literature concerning policy and governance centered on formal systems like legislative policy, administrative policy, funding, and infrastructure. They also centered discussions around community organizing via informal systems of governance. Dr. Monica White highlighted this in the Collective Action and Community Resilience (CACR) framework she used to demonstrate how African American communities used collective agriculture as an organizing unit where commons as praxis, prefigurative politics, and economic autonomy became a means of survival that shielded members from racially discriminatory policies and practices within state and local governments. White established this framework after evaluating how 40 Black agricultural collectives created empowering modes of governance via food systems.^x

Raffaele Maticena highlights a link between alternative food networks (AFNs) and urban policy that could increase the impact, sustainability, governance, and infrastructure of local and regional food systems in the United States. Maticena argues that current food systems monopolize power at the expense of producers, who lose autonomy and profit, and consumers, who lose access to food and connections to their local food systems. AFNs broadly describe efforts that shift food systems away from this paradigm by “re-localizing” and “resocializing” food practices to promote social justice, environmental conservation, economic enfranchisement, and better food access. While AFNs show promising potential, there are still shortcomings. Unless backed by institutional efforts, AFNs often face issues with scalability and logistics. Maticena also notes that research evidence measuring the impacts of AFNs on larger

economies is insufficient. These considerations position the future of sustainable food systems somewhere between alternative and conventional methods. Urban food policy and food policy councils emerge in that space as vehicles to make AFNs more economically viable, infrastructurally sound, and sustainable while localizing power and reconnecting the broken links between producers and consumers. Putting food on the urban policy agenda strikes a balance in food system governance that could create transformational change.^{xi}

Theme 3 – Urbanicity impact food security in distinct ways that are not fully measured

Ackerman et al. propose urban agriculture as a potential solution to the growing problem of food insecurity in New York City. The authors highlight the potential economic benefits of additional household income from garden products, less money spent on foods, and jobs created by urban agricultural efforts. They also argue that community gardens, farmers markets, and CSAs create channels within a local food system where farmers can get better access to urban consumers, especially in communities where traditional retailers avoid establishing grocery stores. The Metro Atlanta area is not comparable to New York City; however, they share characteristics like “inadequate healthy food access, high incidence of diet-related disease, a greater percentage of vacant land”^{xii}.

Bezuneh and Yiheyis expand the USDA measure of food insecurity to evaluate how low-income communities perceive and cope with food insufficiency. They found that in low-income communities, food insecurity prevalence was chronically high, households that were not officially food insecure still struggled to afford food, public benefits were not always adequate support, and community members had to adopt various methods to afford food. This study described unexpected findings in reported happiness. Food security was generally associated with well-being; however, individuals experiencing food insecurity still reported happiness. These findings suggest that various components impact happiness amongst respondents, including social support and community engagement. Considering the underestimated severity of food insecurity and the various methods that low-income communities use to cope with that reality, food systems that embed community members directly into operations have the potential to be both a coping strategy and a means towards food and economic security.^{xiii}

Food insecurity research often focuses on specific populations to gain insight into barriers to accessing food. One study employed a quantitative analysis of a large sample of older adults to evaluate differences in food insecurity by various socio-demographic factors. Compared to older adults living in rural and suburban areas, those who lived in urban clusters and core urban areas had a higher prevalence of food insecurity because of the traditional drivers of food insecurity, like poverty and living far away from healthy food sources. Additionally, older adults who had limited mobility, less domestic support, and lived in older urban communities had higher instances of food insecurity. This research effort created a

snapshot of spatial differences in food insecurity that researchers could replicate for various socio-demographic factors.^{xiv}

Conclusion

Food systems research is future-facing. Three of the referenced resources conceptualize what changes need to be made to current food systems to make them more efficient and equitable. This indicates a need for more research on the current landscapes of food systems that specifically detail what works, what does not, and what might work in the future. Food systems research is concerned with organizing space, power, and people in ways that promote social justice. The literature cites social, economic, or environmental justice as major components in food systems research. Across these various focuses, research efforts converge on the conclusion that food insecurity is a public health problem. Many research efforts document this, but there is not a significant amount of research evaluating the mechanisms within food systems that perpetuate food insecurity or protect people from it.

Methods

Research Design and Methods

The research design included three in-depth interviews with community agricultural stakeholders within the Metro Atlanta area. In-depth interviews aimed to extract community agricultural stakeholders' perceptions concerning their communal and commercial food systems, their interactions with them, and their perceived role in addressing food security. To that end, the present study used the Collective Action and Community Resilience (CACR) theoretical framework to inform interview guide questions.^{xv}

Sampling

This study utilized a purposive sampling strategy to recruit community agricultural stakeholders working in formal institutions, organizations, private enterprises, or grassroots operations in the Metro Atlanta area. Because these individuals have a vested interest in the food landscapes around them, they are information-rich participants who have an insider perspective on the workings of both communal and commercial food system components.

Recruitment

This study employed formal and informal network recruitment strategies. Additionally, enabled by years of participation in food systems volunteer work in the Metro Atlanta area, the principal researcher functioned as gatekeeper to this intended audience. In that capacity, they made direct contact with one strong pre-established network tie and four weak pre-established network ties via text message and the social media platform, Instagram. This initial contact included a brief reintroduction of the researcher and a description of the research project.

Interested parties shared an email address where the principal researchers sent a short screening questionnaire to determine eligibility. The screening questionnaire included the following questions: 1) Are you an adult over 18? 2) Are you a resident of the Metro Atlanta Area? 3) Are you engaged in agricultural, or food systems work within the Metro Atlanta Area?

Respondents who indicated that they were adults engaged in agricultural, or food systems work in the Metro Atlanta area met the inclusion criteria. Respondents who worked within commercial food systems logistics, like transportation or food processing, did not meet the inclusion criteria. Respondents who engaged in agricultural or food systems work in the Metro Atlanta area but indicated no role in the food system still met the inclusion criteria. No respondents were excluded based on the exclusion criteria, so the principal researcher sent follow-up email correspondence describing the study objective in detail.

Analytic Methods

Before data collection, the principal researcher produced reflexive memos detailing how their participation in Metro Atlanta area food systems work might impact their position, assumptions, and biases; and strategized ways to mitigate that potential impact. Analytic memos from each interview included high-level summaries, first reactions, notes about similarities or differences across interviews, and potential inductive codes. The next steps involved rereading each interview transcript and further developing analytic memos with themes, patterns, connections, and potential inductive codes across the three interviews.

Codebook development started with deductive codes compiled from the interview guide, the literature review, the Collective Action and Community Resilience (CACR) theoretical framework, and the principal researcher's volunteer experience (see Appendix 1). The inductive coding process involved rereading each interview stored in Microsoft Word and applying the pre-determined deductive codes to phrases and sentences by highlighting them in a color matching the corresponding code. During this rereading, inductive codes were developed as well. Coded textual data was transferred to Microsoft Excel for further analysis. In one workbook, each column included a code, and the rows in these columns included the corresponding raw data creating a matrix of information that could be easily maneuvered and manipulated. Next, the principal researcher analyzed codes to assess where they connect, converge, and diverge into themes that answer the present research question.

Data Collection

Three 45–60-minute interviews with community agricultural stakeholders in the Metro Atlanta area were conducted using Zoom video conferencing. All interviews were audio recorded and the Otter.ai platform simultaneously produced transcripts of each conversation. The principal researcher manually revised interview transcripts to ensure they were verbatim and anonymous, and included any non-verbal cues observed during the interview.

Before interviews began, the principal researcher read a prompt describing the research objectives and potential ethical issues. The researcher also asked for verbal consent to conduct the interview and record it. This study did not require an Institutional Review Board. However, it was conducted under the same principles of respect for persons by obtaining informed consent, privacy and confidentiality by anonymizing transcripts to avoid participant exposure, and justice by not including and/or exploiting vulnerable populations.

The data collection tool was an interview guide composed of 13 open-ended questions. Findings from the literature review, framing from CACR, and insight from volunteer experience with the intended audience informed the interview guide questions. Given the wide reach of these reference materials, a questions crosswalk helped narrow the scope of the interview questions to answer the research question directly. The interview guide had the following sections: demographic questions, an icebreaker question to build rapport, opening questions about the participant's contributions to their local food system, key questions about their perception of the communal and commercial food systems, key questions about their participation across the two, key questions about their personal and/or profession experience with food insecurity, and closing questions that asked participants to conceptualize their ideal food system futures (see Appendix 2).

Results

The study sample included a farmers market manager, a farm educator, and a food systems consultant. Their experience in food systems work in the Metro Atlanta area ranges from four to ten years. Their food systems work takes place in various Metro Atlanta counties including Henry, Bibb, and Clayton; however, they all lived and worked in Fulton County for most of their time in Atlanta.

Research findings answered the question of what community agricultural stakeholders perceive their role to be in Metro Atlanta food systems and in addressing food insecurity via the following themes:

Theme 1: Mending legacies of harm via community relationships

All participants detail historic and ongoing systemic and institutional harm within commercial food systems. Participant One argues that while non-local food sourcing allows commercial retailers to offer a variety of food, it calls into question the integrity of the ethics behind that sourcing process. They use the common practice of treating foods with chemicals and deceptively mislabeling food as organic to exemplify this. Locality allows for more transparency, and therefore accountability because the food is closer to the people who distribute and consume it. Participant Three critiques all the "food miles" involved in the commercial food system where "farmers grow [food], it goes to a factory, gets processed, goes

to some other factory, gets cooled off or stored, gets to the back of the truck, and ends up here in Atlanta. Airplanes come in from all over the world to Atlanta” ... “We have a heavily fueled food system here in Atlanta.”

Participant Two observed the social harm perpetuated via commercial food system components. They described how the neighborhood they live and work in experienced urban neglect and divestment. When a few low-income housing developments were demolished and replaced with condos and luxury apartments, they started seeing commercial retailers investing in their community. To cope with that neglect, many residents within that neighborhood—who were “either very recently coming out of food insecurity or [were] still in the process of trying to find economic stability” relied on food distribution through school programs to supplement their diets and nutritional needs.

Urban food divestment is also perpetuated by city officials and local government via inequitable zoning practices. Participant Two describes a strip of land in Southwest, Atlanta that once housed independent retailers and bustling foot traffic. Their farm education program used to host markets there in collaboration with these retailers. Because that strip of land was zoned as residential, that pocket of space that once facilitated economic exchange no longer exists. Now participant Two must “find alternative places that are farther away from where [their] students are living, and from the community that they are actually a part of.” They label city planning and zoning practices as discriminatory because they prioritize investments in the recreational needs of high-income communities, like the construction of the Atlanta Beltline while neglecting the basic infrastructural needs of lower-income neighborhoods.

Participant Three describes a vivid analogy of the consequences of chronic food insecurity perpetuated by urban food environments. They said, “It's an angry, hungry bear, and it's a bear that hasn't hibernated. It hasn't eaten well before hibernation. Can't hibernate, can't rest because there's no food around. That's the urban legend and the urban food environment where there is less food and the food that is available is processed.” Participants One and Two attribute these practices to the broader harms of a capitalistic regime. Participant one argues that “there are a lot of things that cannot grow and root themselves in capitalism” and that capitalism itself breeds food insecurity. Participant two posits that “the commercial food system is a part of our larger capitalistic system, and isolating people is a strategy to increase profit.” They used the treatment of unhoused individuals at various grocery stores and food service establishments as an example of that isolation. When asked about the consequences of these systemic and institutional harms, they responded with a myriad of chronic health issues like high blood pressure and kidney disease.

In contrast, Participant Two says that in the communal food system, “there's an underlying knowledge that everyone deserves to access food, and that changes how people interact. There is a baseline understanding that every person deserves to eat, that doesn't exist necessarily in the commercial food system.” Participant Three says that the communal food

system addressed food insecurity head-on. Study participants demonstrate exactly how in the accounts of their food systems participation. For example, in response to urban divestment and neglect, Participant Two delineates a four-year process where the educational farm program established a safety net for food security via direct food distribution and community partnerships. Even without commercial investments, their efforts led to the opening of a small full-service grocery store within walking distance of their neighborhood. Community agricultural stakeholders are also building community and mending harm by intentionally moving through conflict. Participant One argues that there is no space for conflict in capitalism, so they established an advisory board for the farmers in the market they managed to ensure that they had dedicated spaces to facilitate conflict resolution.

Participant Three prides themselves in making people aware of the possibilities in their local food systems. Their goals for consulting include helping clients of all ages gain confidence in their agricultural work via demonstration, preparation, and encouraging words. Participant One sees their role in addressing food insecurity as “connecting people to more farmers, highlighting more Black and Brown farmers in the Global South, training and encouraging more people to become farmers in the Global South, supporting and loving on more farmers, and building community with them in the Global South.” Across all participants, communal connection was a consistent remedy for the discriminatory and negligent aspects of commercial food systems.

Theme 2: Creating choices that cater to the food, economic, cultural, and sovereign needs of their communities.

Commercial food systems components offer a variety of foods via non-local sourcing practices and agricultural infrastructure, like tunnel hoops, that extend growing seasons. However, food insecurity limits the choices people make within that abundance. Study participants described this reality in detail and included the intentional strategy they used to combat this. In commercial food systems, food insecurity impacts choices people make concerning food. Participant One describes how individuals may opt to buy heavily processed canned foods and frozen meals because they lack time as a resource to interact with fresh and local foods. Time is directly linked to income so individuals experiencing food insecurity have compounding experiences of limited choice because of affordability and time restraints. Participant One sees this issue exacerbated by commercial food retailers exemplified by the prevalence of non-local fast-food restaurant chains in low-income, Black, and Brown communities versus locally sourced “slow foods” and sit-down venues prevalent in higher-income communities.

Study participants’ critiques of choice extend to communal food system components when they question, “are the food in communal food systems catering to the needs of everyone in this community.” According to Participant One, the nonprofit space heavily supports urban agriculture, and “is dominated by white leadership, founders, and funders.” This

is important to them because “when addressing food insecurity there should be a level of accountability and recognition of cultural sensitivity for food landscapes to become even more accessible.” Participant Two sees cultural importance as a fundamental part of communal food systems. They describe how having access to specific crops is important to personal and cultural histories and used mustard greens as an example of this. Participant Two looks forward to growing and distributing them to elders in their neighborhood because they grew up eating them and are the keepers of the knowledge of cooking them. These greens are farm favorites because they are not always available in grocery stores, and “the informal food system is how people are keeping access to those kinds of crops”

Participant Two takes a firm stance on the fact they are working beyond food insecurity, towards food sovereignty. To them that looks like hyper-local systems where producers receive direct feedback from consumers and can tailor production in ways that allow for true freedom and autonomy in what they eat. To them, sovereignty extends to economic opportunity because it “looks like having the choice to a commercial food producer or not and having that barrier to entry lowered” so that “folks wouldn't have to leave their communities.” Participant Two conceptualizes a middle ground with a mixture of commercial and communal food networks as options rather than necessities. There are food businesses or food centers that always address the needs and desires of a community. Still people also have the space, knowledge, and desire to build their gardens, raise their animals, process their foods, and redistribute them.

Participant Three echoes this sentiment and describes how that conceptualization could come to be. They detail a food system, “under the food system” that will soon enhance the current food system of “factory food.” While the current “factory food system” is the dominant practice, Participant Three is feeding knowledge of local food practices to the masses to build up the communal food system. Participant Three sees the dominant commercial food system as both a tool and a means to an end where there is ultimately more freedom of choice.

Theme 3: Creating the food systems infrastructure that exist within and between communal and commercial food systems

Participant One sees their role as providing a “consistent, sustainable, accessible space for community members and neighbors to access fresh local produce, curated businesses, and crafted goods.” They emphasize the importance of their role when stating, “I view my role as attempting to be as consistent as a brick and mortar” ... “and understanding how monumental that consistency is in operating that event for my farmers, my vendors, and also in return the community.” Participant Two is building economic potential via the student entrepreneur program stemming from the educational farm they manage. They are currently working towards getting the on-site teach kitchen commercially certified so that students can develop individual food and agriculture businesses integrated into their local food systems. Participant Three likens their role to a bridge between the government and the people. They argue that

local government and commercial food retailers are important resources to the masses, and part of their job is making people aware of those resources.

Communal agricultural stakeholders maintain these infrastructural components with policies for themselves and their collaborators. When considering partnerships, a major condition Participant Two has for engagement is whether the potential partner accepts the current conditions in Atlanta's urban food landscape. To them, it is imperative "that they be trying to work themselves out of a job." For collaborators in both communal and commercial spaces they state, "It boils down to, 'are you okay with how things are right now?' And if the answer is yes, then we cannot work together." Additionally, they are looking to see if organizations are extractive. They question what they aim to gain from engagement with students and the community and evaluate organizational values. Participant Three applauds the grassroots efforts established around community agriculture in the Metro Atlanta area. They also mourn how the current presidential administration has dismantled pivotal structures, like the Farm-to-school Network in Georgia.

Participant Three describes how different communal and commercial food system components across the Metro Atlanta area are interconnected like the spokes on a bicycle wheel connected to a central hub. These hubs include hospitals, churches, schools, and universities. Participant Three's role is connecting people to these hubs, teaching people at these hubs about good food and agricultural practices and getting hubs to work together in a symbiotic way. Adding a pragmatic lens to these research findings, Participant Two argues that the current commercial and communal food systems, and the places where they intersect—like in many nonprofit institutions that Participant One astutely coined as "local commercial"—are not sustainable pathways to equity or freedom. While they consider these systems to be deeply flawed, they concede that they still must work within them to some degree.

Through the interconnected veins of this food system infrastructure flows information, resources, shared power, and skills. Participant Two described a bidirectional flow of knowledge and material resources when working with local farmers to host educational programs or supply workshop materials. That flow extends to other farm educators via the organization they founded to support farm education efforts. Participant One is hyper-focused on resource and knowledge redistribution to Black and Brown communities. That includes supporting advocacy efforts through mutual aid. Participant Three aims to continue exposing people to new foods and agricultural practices via the network of people they already work with. They described how on that very day, they had their older students help them teach children at a daycare how to plant and grow food on an on-site garden.

Theme 4: Community agricultural stakeholders practice the food system futures they believe will address food insecurity.

When asked about their ideal future food system, Participant One saw their role as an independent producer amongst other producers. Their network would produce a variety of

offerings—made up of the things they love—towards collective survival. Participant One hopes this network will be creative and community-based. Participant Three described a dream team of their top five farmers they would clone and send across the earth to support food systems, both commercial and communal, in ways that address food insecurity.

Participant Two is currently creating programs to model youth investment through food agriculture and operationalize food and agriculture to address economic justice. They aim for these programs to persist beyond them. They make clear that these efforts are a means to an end. That is a future where “community members are the owners of, the recipients of, and the change-makers in their local food system.” An ideal system where “employment and entrepreneurship opportunities exist within their neighborhood so that people do not have to be displaced.” Their description transcends charity and repair and centers on justice as the ideal. That ideal looks like a future where knowledge about food production and preservation is shared less formally, through households as a fundamental life skill. Where the communal food system does not mainly serve to fill in the gaps of the commercial food system. They envision a holistic food system made possible when basic needs are met. Where families have both the freedom and material means to share recipes, garden spaces, produce, and plates.

Across these four themes, research findings indicate that community agricultural stakeholders are the foundation of communal food systems. They operate within and alongside commercial food systems and often leverage communal methods to address food access issues in commercial systems. They do so with the goal of justice in mind. Right now, they operate within communal and commercial spaces to address the systemic realities that breed food insecurity. Their work is two-fold because they are also modeling and facilitating the food system dynamics they want to see in the future.

Discussion

Study implications

Root cause work will address the extensively documented connection between food insecurity and poor health outcomes. Community agricultural stakeholders are at the root of communal and commercial food systems. They have valuable insider perspectives on what policies, norms, and practices oppose or enable food insecurity. Both public health research and practice must engage these key informants to better understand the pathways between food insecurity and poor health outcomes. These findings should push researchers to prioritize community agricultural stakeholders as subject matter experts. Practitioners should widen the scope of chronic and diet-related illness interventions to consider food environments. For researchers and practitioners, these findings require a deeper interrogation of food systems as a social determinant of health.

Study Limitations

One study limitation was the researcher's affiliation with Emory University. In previous interactions with community agricultural stakeholders, the principal researcher observed a range of opposition to general institutional efforts and Emory University specifically. This opposition stems from general distrust, concerted efforts to decenter academic institutions in community research, and Emory University's proximity to efforts that uphold systemic racism in the Metro Atlanta Area. An example of the latter includes the Georgia International Law Enforcement Exchange (GILEE) program and the destruction of the Weelaunee forest in favor of constructing a training facility for Atlanta police, often referred to as Cop City. [xvi] Another limitation was the small sample size of this study. This research topic was specific, but the various considerations it provoked were expansive. It required more than three interviews to reach saturation.

Positionality Statement

The present research study is a product of my personal experiences volunteering with a network of land stewards and food producers in Georgia. I continue to support their efforts to grow food, protect ancestral land, and denounce racial discrimination. This experience inspired me to join an ecofeminist collective to coordinate mutual aid efforts alongside Black farmers and youth. This experience also has a high chance of biasing my research efforts because it is this very context that shaped my research interests. I used constant self-reflection and strict adherence to qualitative research protocol to help mitigate any potential bias.

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Appendix 1

Interview Guide Questions:

Introduction Script: Thank you for taking the time to speak with me. My name is Sofia Charlot, and I am a first-year student Master of Public Health Student at Emory University Rollins School of Public Health. Today I am going to be asking you some questions to better understand your views on food systems within the Metro Atlanta Area. This interview is being conducted as part of a mini research study on the public health problem of food insecurity. This problem disproportionately impacts Black and Brown peoples leading to higher rates of chronic illness. I am interested in public health research that addresses this problem by highlighting the assets within Black and Brown communities that promote food security. That's what led me to recruit you for this study!

Ethical Issues: This interview is entirely voluntary. You will not receive any direct benefits from participating in this research. While there are also no significant risks associated with participating, there is a possibility that some questions could cause discomfort. Please know that you can stop the interview at anytime or skip any questions you would prefer not to answer. With your consent, I would like to record this interview to ensure I do not forget anything important. I will transcribe the recording shortly after this interview and then destroy the audio file. Any information that could potentially identify you will be removed from the transcript, and the anonymized transcript will only be viewed by me, my classmates, and my instructors. It will not be published anywhere or shared outside the classroom.

Informed consent: Do you have any questions? [pause for response].
Are you willing to participate in this interview? [pause for response].
And is it okay if I start the audio recording now? [pause for response].
Okay, great. Let's go ahead and get started.

Demographic Questions:

1. What is your race and/or ethnicity?
2. What county do you live in?
 - a. How long have you lived there?
 - b. Have you lived in any other county in Metro Atlanta? If so, for how long?
3. What is your profession?
 - a. Do you engage in food systems work outside of that profession?
 - b. In what part of Metro Atlanta do you work?

Icebreaker: If you had to go to another planet where there is no food, what three seeds would you take with you to grow and why (assuming anything can grow in this new environment)?

Opening Questions:

1. How do you contribute to your local food system?
 - a. What do you receive in exchange for your contributions?
 - b. Who do you collaborate with and how?

Next, I'll ask you a few questions about Metro Atlanta area food systems and how you interact with them.

Key Questions:

Commercial and Communal Food Systems

2. How would you describe commercial food systems in the Metro Atlanta area? By commercial food systems I mean the production, processing, distribution, marketing, and consumption of food on a large scale, by commercial retailers, and with the primary goal of profit.
 - a. Food cost, store locations, the supply chain, what foods are available, etc.
3. How would you describe communal food system in the Metro Atlanta area? By communal food systems I mean the production, processing, distribution, marketing, and consumption of food on a local and/or communal scale, by non-commercial retailers, and with the primary goal of providing a social service or addressing a social need.
4. How do you navigate federal, state, or local policy around food production and land?
 - b. What policies do you have for yourself and your collaborators?

Food System Interaction and Participation

5. Where do you source food?
 - a. Who do you get that food from?
 - b. What differences are do you observe between commercial and community sources of food?
6. What components make up the food systems, both commercial and communal, that you interact with in Metro Atlanta?
 - c. How are those components connected?
 - d. How are they disconnected?
 - e. Who controls those components?

Food Insecurity

7. How has food insecurity impacted you, the communities you interact with personally, or the communities you serve through your work?
8. What consequences of food insecurity do you experience personally or see within the communities you interact with or serve?
9. How does the commercial food system in the Metro Atlanta area impact food insecurity?
10. How do you view your role in addressing food insecurity?
 - f. How does your current profession contribute to that?

Thanks for all of that insightful information! To close us out, I'll a few high-level questions about how you'd like Metro Atlanta area food systems to evolve.

Closing Questions:

11. What would an ideal food system look like to you?
 - g. What role would you play in that ideal system?
 - h. What role would your peers and partners play in that system?
 - i. How would it impact food insecurity?

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12. What do you think will need to change about the current Metro Atlanta commercial and/or communal food systems to achieve that?
 13. Do you have any questions for me, or any additional points you'd like to share?
 14. Would you like me to share a copy of the findings with you once the study is complete?

Appendix 2

Inductive and Deductive Codes

Code	Definition	Clarifying Note
Demographics	Apply this code for demographic details	This will include demographic and geographic characteristics
Location	Apply this code for the discussion of the physical locations where food systems work takes place.	This won't include identifiable locations and their names but rather details about where components within food systems are located i.e. urban, suburban, rural, specific counties are, etc.
Food System Participation (FSP)	Professional and volunteer work within the production, processing, distribution, marketing, and consumption of food. Participation as consumers within commercial and communal food systems.	Includes ways in which community agricultural stakeholders participate as consumers, producers, educators, professionals, etc.
Subcode: FSP_Autonomy & Sovereignty	The discussion of community-led initiatives, resource ownership, and participation in systems and practices that deviate from societal norms.	Will primarily focus on communal autonomy rather than individual free will.
Subcode: FSP_Collaboration	Apply this code for the discussion of collaboration between community agricultural stakeholders and partnerships across commercial and communal food systems.	Includes formal (i.e. contracts, partnerships, Memorandum of Understandings (MOU)) and informal (i.e. mutual aid/exchanges, agreements amongst neighbors) collaboration.
Subcode: FSP_Connection	Apply this code for the discussion of the distribution of knowledge, resources, and relationships	

Subcode: FSP_Culture	Use to describe cultural considerations	
Food System Components (FSC)	The components that facilitate the production, processing, distribution, marketing, and consumption of food	This includes the physical components themselves and the connections between them that allow them to operate within a food system.
Subcodes: FSC_Commercial	Commercial: the production, processing, distribution, marketing, and consumption of food on a large scale, by commercial retailers, and with the primary goal of profit.	Community agricultural stakeholder makes the distinction explicitly. It will also be noted where they don't make a distinction.
Subcode: FSC_Communal	Communal: the production, processing, distribution, marketing, and consumption of food on a local and/or communal scale, by non-commercial retailers, and with the primary goal of providing a social service or addressing a social need	Community agricultural stakeholder makes the distinction explicitly. It will also be noted where they don't make a distinction.
Subcode: FSC_Crossover (Commercial & Communal Crossover)	Use to describe where systems crossover	
Formal Policy & Legislation	Federal, state, or local legislative or administrative policy around land, food, and agriculture that impact food system components.	Will only include policies that directly impact food systems work or participation in the Metro Atlanta area.
Personal Policy	Use to describe personal edicts and policies	
Neoliberalism	The discussion of supply, demand, and profit as a priority in food system operations; as well as privatization, redevelopment, deregulation, reduced social safety nets, individualism, and environmental disregard.	Will focus on the ways in which the principles of neoliberalism show up within Metro Atlanta food systems. Will also focus on ways in which food systems work against this principle.
Food Insecurity (FI)	The participant's personal experiences with food insecurity, observations about the experience of food insecurity in the participant's community, and observations about the magnitude of food insecurity.	Will include discussion of the presence of food insecurity and the participant's perceived role in addressing it.
Subcodes: FI_Cost	Cost: the affordability of food and the variability of cost	Will capture the drivers of food insecurity that participants specifically witness in their

		experiences, the experiences of their community and peers, and their food systems work.
FI_Physical location	Physical location: the proximity or distance of food sources	
FI_Quality and quantity	Quality: the types of food present and the condition of it	
FI_Role	Role: the ways in which study participants describe their role in addressing food insecurity.	
Food System Futures	Discussion of the future goals of the participant's food systems work, their projections for the future of food systems, and their hopes for the future of food systems.	If participants mention what they project will happen or what they hope will happen in the future regarding Metro Atlanta food systems.
Justice	Use to describe discussion around institutional repair	